לך לך. I heard this vort from my טייערע son-in-law Dovid Tribuch, who heard it from R' Ephraim Goldberg. When Avram leaves חרן and is coming to ארץ ישראל, Hashem gives him a tremendous הבטחה: וַאֲבָרְכָה מְבָרְכֶיךָ וּמְקַלֶּלְךָ אָאֹר. (12:3) Rabbi Goldberg asked an interesting question. וַאֲבָרְכָה - whoever benches you; מְבָרְכֶיךָ - will be benched, I will bench them. Both words are the same verb. However, וּמְקַלֶּלְךָ - if they curse you, it doesn't say אקלל, it says אָאֹר, a completely different verb. What do we learn from that?

Rabbi Goldberg answers that if somebody benches us, Hashem will bench him. But if somebody curses us, what happens? Will that curse have any effect on us? What is כלל ישראל's reaction to a curse? What is כלל ישראל's reaction to any attack? We get together. Unfortunately, we've learned that the hard way. Despite our internal bickering, strife and fighting, if we're attacked, all of a sudden we are עם אחד, we get together, we unify. Hashem has to send us enemies to unify us. וּמְקַלֶּלְךָ אָאֹר can be translated as "I will make you shine" from the לשון of אור. When they curse you, you will shine. You will be great. You'll be unified and you'll bring out the best that's in כלל ישראל. We don't curse anybody back. We become stronger, try to do תשובה, and be better people.

Speaking of being better people, what should our focus be? When Avram and Sarah were going to מצרים, Avram noticed that Sarah is beautiful (12:11) וַיְהִי כַּאֲשֶׁר הִקְרִיב לָבוֹא מִצְרָיְמָה וַיֹּאמֶר אֶל שָׂרַי אִשְׁתּוֹ הִנֵּה נָא יָדַעְתִּי כִּי אִשָּׁה יְפַת מַרְאֶה אָתְּ - Now I know that you are a beautiful, very attractive woman. Rashi says on these words מִדְרַשׁ אַגָּדָה עַד עַכְשָׁו לֹא הִכִּיר בָּהּ מִתּוֹךְ צְנִיעוּת שֶׁבִּשְׁנֵיהֶם - Avram did not recognize her beauty because of their צניעות, their modesty; וְעַכְשָׁו הִכִּיר בָּהּ עַל יְדֵי מַעֲשֶׂה - But now he recognized it because they were in a situation where it will become an issue, become something to deal with.

The קשיא posed by Rav Pinchas Doron from ארץ ישראל in his sefer ביאור סתומות ברש"י is that a חתן has to see his כלה at least one time before they get married. Avram already recognized Sarah, he already knew of her beauty. Why is Avram saying now, הִנֵּה נָא יָדַעְתִּי כִּי אִשָּׁה יְפַת מַרְאֶה אָתְּ - Now I know you're beautiful, he already knew that?

He gives a profound answer. A person can have beauty of various types. We are so used to recognizing the greatness and the majesty of אברהם אבינו, and all of us בני תורה don't recognize, at least not as on the spot, not as instinctively, the greatness and the majesty of שרה אמנו. אברהם אבינו recognized שרה אמנו for the person that she was, for her inner strength and beauty. Her beauty did not lie in her externality, her beauty was internal, it was part of her מהות. Her majesty and beauty was something so overwhelming to Avram that her external beauty paled in comparison. It didn't even affect him; he didn't even realize that she was beautiful, because she was such an outstanding, beautiful person. But now that they were coming to מצרים, where there were people whose only conception of importance was externality and superficiality, Avram said, "Uh oh, now we have to recognize this because it could cause an issue." Rashi is saying that it's only because of the מעשה that he now recognized the greatness of her external beauty and said, "We have to deal with it." But he really knew who she was, exactly what she looked like. She was such a majestic person that her external beauty served absolutely no purpose in their relationship and they were wonderful together at a tremendously high level of spirituality and majesty, which is also what our focus should be.